

Pollination

Watch a patch of flowers on a summer's day and you will soon see a bee or a butterfly. Many flowers need these insects for pollination (the transfer of pollen from plant to plant).

Take a close look

Pollination happens when pollen from one plant's anthers is carried to the stigma of another. The pollen then fertilizes an egg in the ovary, the first step to making a seed.



Normal light



Ultra-violet light

Landing lights

This flower looks plain yellow to us, but insects can see ultra-violet light. This shows up patterns on flowers called nectar guides. They point out exactly where the nectar is in the flower, leading insects straight to it.



Pollination facts

- A honeybee may visit 10,000 flowers in one day.
- Bees account for 80 per cent of all insect pollination.
- Some plants rely on the same insect for pollination, others may be pollinated by several different insects.